

— THE OVERTHINKING TOOLKIT

How do you **really** cope?

Everyone has ways of dealing with stress. Some of them help you for years. Some feel brilliant tonight and send the bill next month. This tool helps you tell which is which.

Coping strategies are the things you do to handle hard feelings. Some are **adaptive**: they help you deal with the situation in a healthy way. Others are **non-adaptive**: they take the edge off now but can make things worse in the long run.

Overthinking usually has a fear sitting underneath it. When that fear never gets looked at, the old coping habits take over. This exercise helps you spot yours and swap the ones that are costing you.

— BEFORE YOU START, KEEP IN MIND

- ✓ **It depends on the situation.** A strategy that is healthy in one moment can be a trap in another. Anything overdone turns non-adaptive.
- ✓ **Ask the long-term question.** What happens in five years if I keep coping like this? That one question sorts most of them.
- ✓ **Know why the habit hurts.** To really change it, name why it costs you. Then pick a replacement and a concrete first step.

Next: the wheel of 12 common strategies



TWELVE COMMON STRATEGIES

Which ones are yours?

Circle the ones you use. Be honest, nobody is marking it. Then turn the page to see what each one really means.



THE TWELVE, EXPLAINED

Keep, or **replace?**

KEEP

Helps long term

1 Let go of what you can't steer
Some things are not yours to steer. Spend your energy on what you can change or influence, and leave the rest alone.

2 Move your body
A walk, a run, a stretch. It burns off tension and drags you out of your head and into your body.

3 Worry journal
Write the thoughts down so you can see them. Bonus: you start to notice the same patterns repeating.

4 Time management
Lists, timers, a clear next hour. Less chaos in the diary means less noise in your head.

5 Self-talk that helps
Swap the harsh inner commentary for something you would say to a friend. Believable beats bubbly.

6 Take the next step
Write down a plan, even a rough one, and do the first bit while it still feels scary. Momentum calms the mind.

WATCH

Costs you later

7 Constant comparison
Measuring yourself against everyone else's highlights. It breeds inadequacy and a loop of 'what is wrong with me'.

8 Overanalyzing
Researching for the 'perfect' option or hunting for reassurance. More information, more stress, no decision.

9 Unhelpful thinking styles
All-or-nothing, catastrophising, 'I should'. The brain's shortcuts that make every option look worse than it is.

10 Perfectionism
Standards no human could meet, followed by the pressure of missing them. Sometimes good enough is the brave answer.

11 Procrastination
Putting it off because it scares you. The task grows, the dread grows, the weekend disappears.

12 Escapism
Scrolling, bingeing, daydreaming, anything to not look at it. Relief now, the same problem tomorrow.

QUICK CHECK

Look at the numbers you circled on the wheel. Count how many are orange and how many are blue. There is no pass mark. It just shows you which way you lean when things get hard.

Name _____

Date _____

1 What do you currently do to cope with overthinking and anxiety?

2 Has it helped? How? And if not, how is it hurting you?

3 What are the long-term consequences of coping this way?

Picture yourself 5 to 10 years from now if nothing changes. Include the good and the bad.

4 Which strategy will you adopt this week, and what is the very first thing you will do?